
The French-type center

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KIA-01 - Re1 supports e4 and makes e5 more credible. Black has a broad d5-c5 center and may expand on the queenside while White builds a kingside initiative.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Check whether e5 is safe, then consider Nf1 and h4 only if the center is stable. White's queen bishop needs a route, often through f4 or g5 after development.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

Black can play ...Qc7, ...b5 or ...dxe4. A kingside attack is premature if e4 can simply be captured.

RECOGNITION TEST

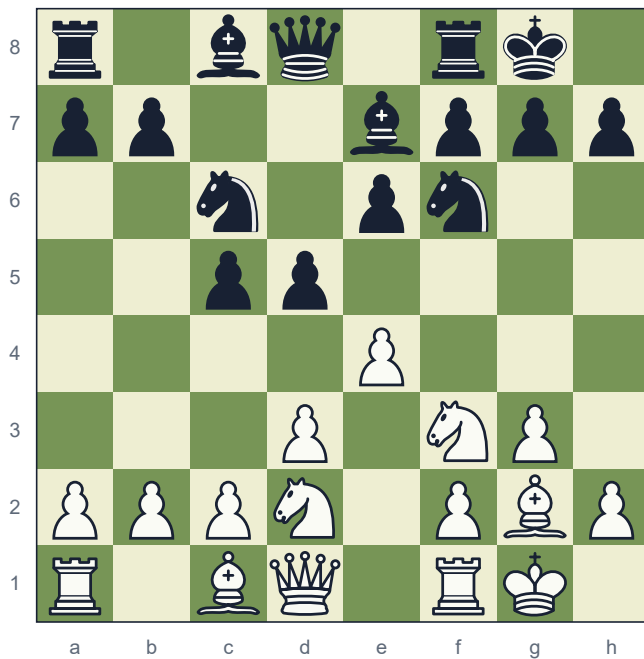
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KIA-01 / The core French-type position

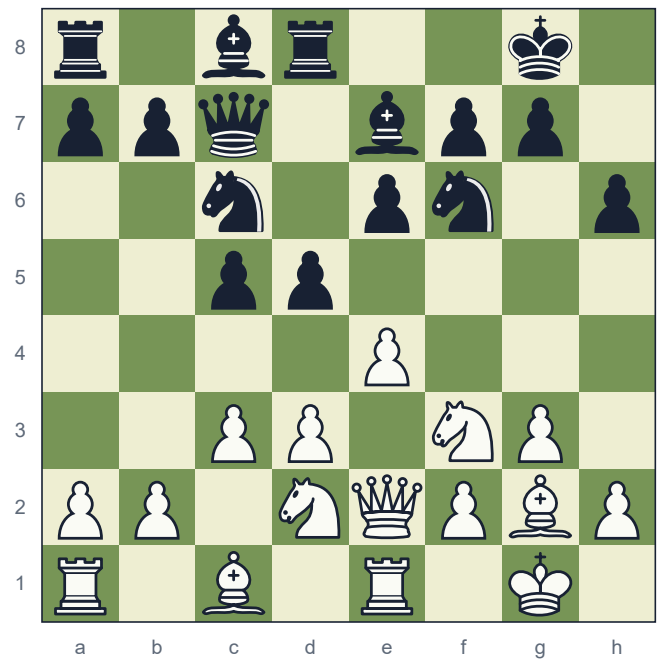
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1 Qc7 9. c3 h6 10. Qe2 Rd8

Authored anchor ends after 8. Re1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Re1 supports e4 and makes e5 more credible. Black has a broad d5-c5 center and may expand on the queenside while White builds a kingside initiative.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Check whether e5 is safe, then consider Nf1 and h4 only if the center is stable. White's queen bishop needs a route, often through f4 or g5 after development.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can play ...Qc7, ...b5 or ...dxe4. A kingside attack is premature if e4 can simply be captured.

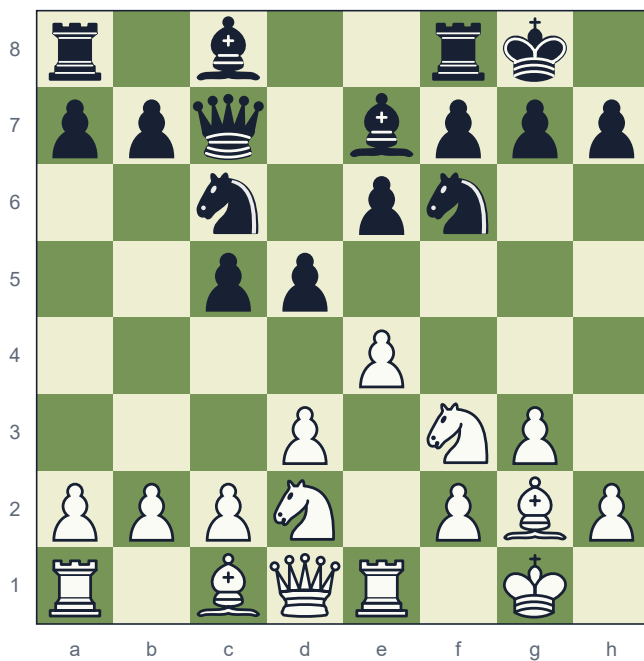
REMEMBER Support e4 before converting it into an e5 wedge.

KIA-02 / The e5 wedge and ...Nd7

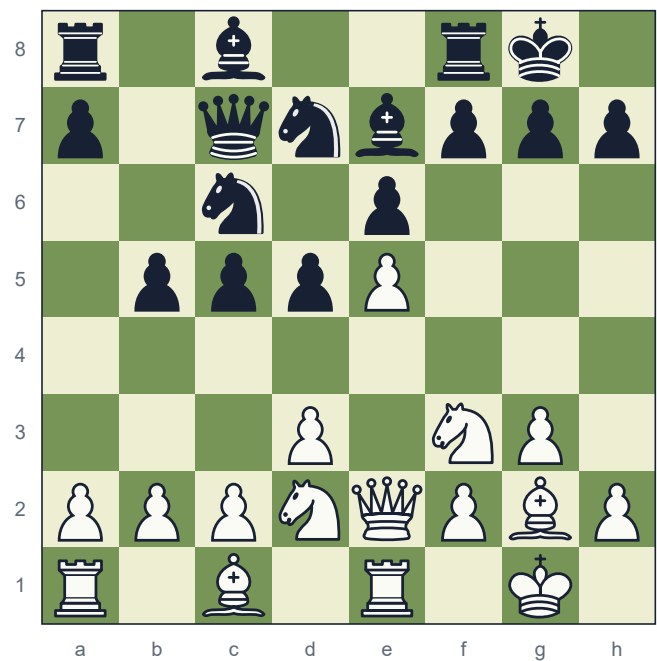
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1 Qc7 9. e5 Nd7 10. Qe2 b5

Authored anchor ends after 9... Nd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Advancing e5 gains space and displaces Nf6, but fixes a pawn that Black can undermine with ...f6. The f1 knight route is now a plan, not a forced continuation.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Improve Nf1-e3 or h2-g4 according to available squares, and use h4 only after inspecting ...f6. Keep d3 defended as Black expands.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can strike at the base or head of the chain. A dramatic wing attack fails if the center opens with your pieces misplaced.

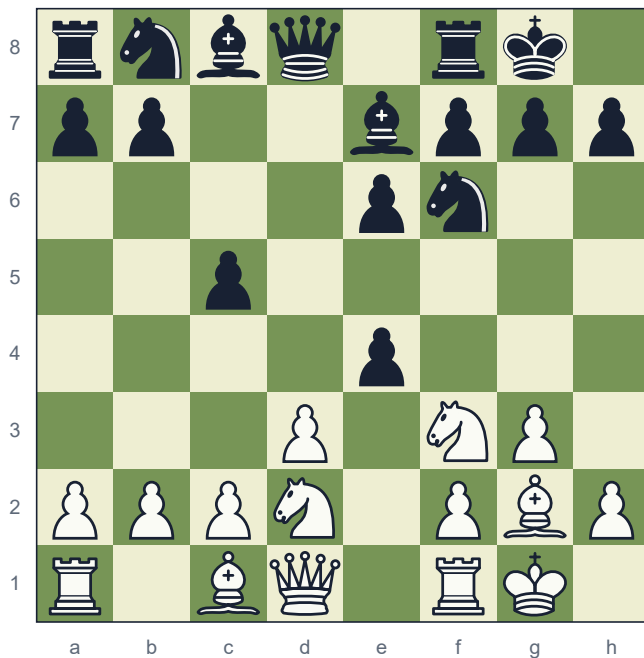
REMEMBER An advanced pawn gives space and creates a target.

KIA-03 / Black exchanges on e4

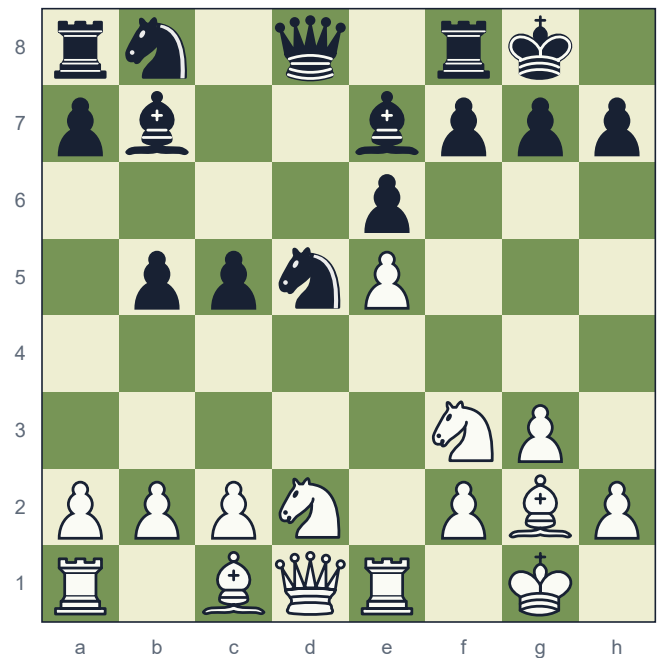
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 dxe4 8. dxe4 b5 9. e5 Nd5 10. Re1 Bb7

Authored anchor ends after 8. dxe4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The central exchange removes the familiar d5-e5 blockade. White's d-pawn becomes an e-pawn, opening the d-file and changing the bishop's prospects.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop on open files and compare piece activity. Use the e4 outpost control and consider Nc4 when it creates a real threat.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

An automatic e5 attack plan may no longer fit. Black can use ...Nc6 and ...Qc7 to put pressure on e4.

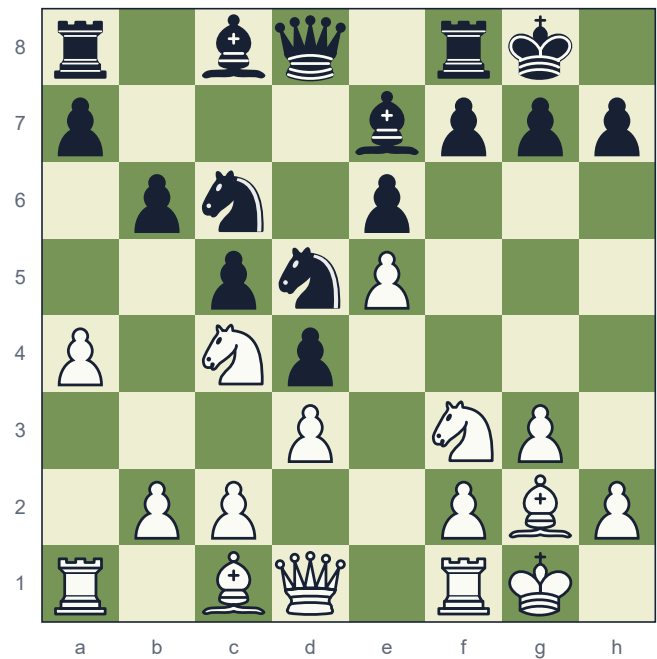
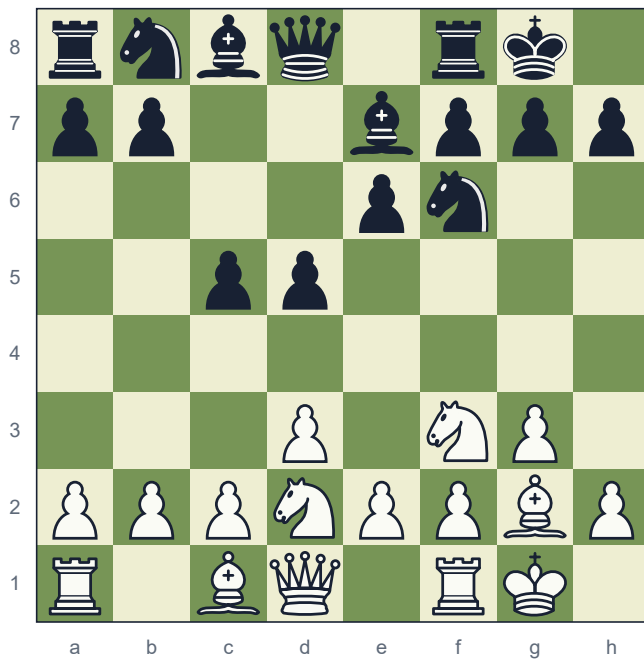
REMEMBER A changed pawn structure requires a changed plan.

KIA-04 / Black closes with ...d4

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 d4 8. a4 b6 9. e5 Nd5 10. Nc4 Nc6

Authored anchor ends after 7... d4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Black gains space and closes the d-file. White must choose where to challenge the chain rather than follow a standard e5 attack by habit.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Consider c3 against d4, or Nc4 if the square is available. Keep the f-pawn flexible until you know whether kingside expansion is safe.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

...Nc6 and ...e5 can consolidate a space advantage. Waiting without a pawn break can leave every white piece short of squares.

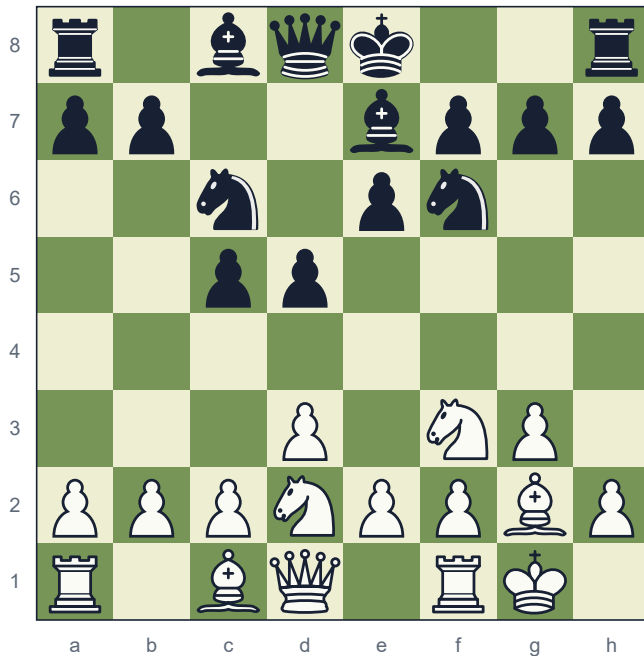
REMEMBER Against a d4 wedge, identify a lever.

KIA-05 / Black delays castling

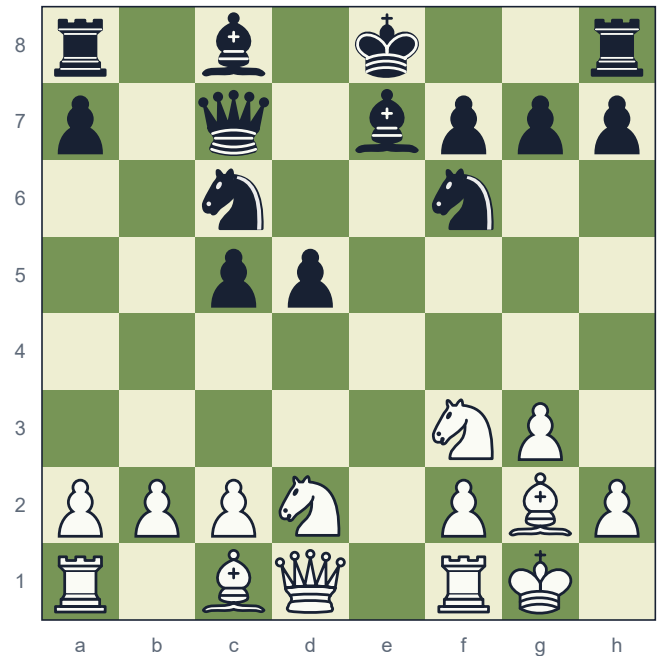
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 c5 6. Nbd2 Nc6 7. e4 Qc7 8. exd5 exd5 9. d4 b6 10. dxc5 bxc5

Authored anchor ends after 7... Qc7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black has not declared the king's destination. White has no automatic target on g8 and should prepare useful central moves first.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Re1 supports e4; e5 can gain space if tactically justified. Wait to see whether Black castles or opens the center before committing the h-pawn.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A pawn storm toward an empty kingside wastes time. Black may answer by exchanging central pawns with the king still flexible.

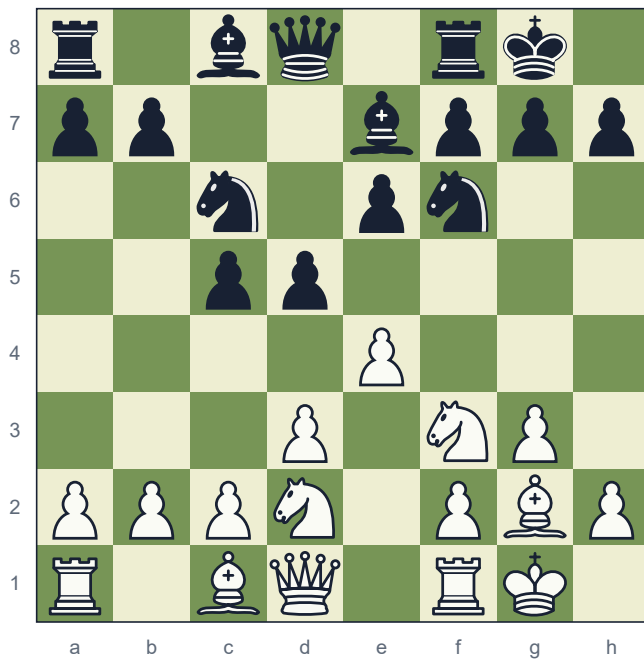
REMEMBER Attack a real king position, not a remembered diagram.

KIA-06 / The direct 1.e4 French route

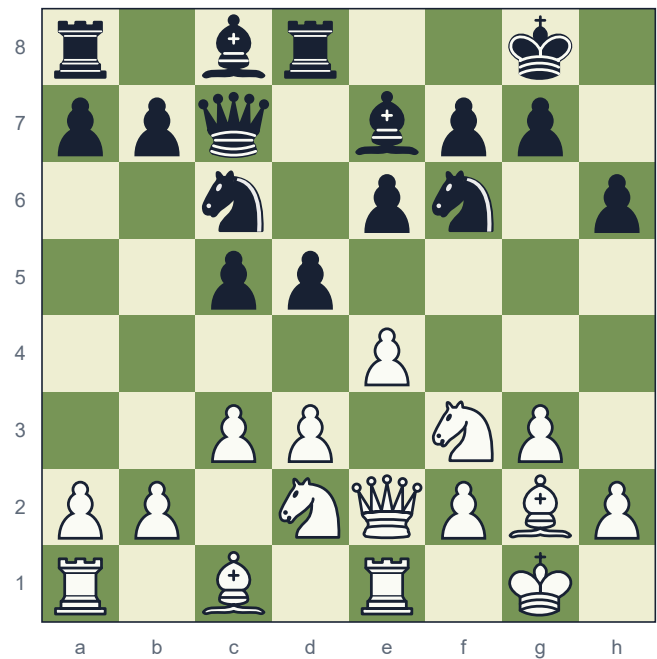
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 c5 5. g3 Nc6 6. Bg2 Be7 7. O-O O-O 8. Re1 Qc7 9. c3 h6 10. Qe2 Rd8

Authored anchor ends after 8. Re1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The same structural idea can be reached with 1.e4 and d3. Nd2 must precede Ngf3 here if White wants this exact arrangement without blocking a knight.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare the position with the 1.Nf3 route by placing every piece, including the queen bishop. Learn the transposition once and keep both entry routes on the map.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black is not forced to play ...Nf6 or ...Be7. Early ...dxe4 or a different bishop development changes the task.

REMEMBER A transposition is a position, not a similar-looking setup.

Work through KIA-01

7. E4

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

8. RE1

Places the rook on the e-file, commonly supporting e4 or preparing pressure against an opposing king or central pawn.

9. C3

Places the pawn on c3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

10. QE2

Places the queen on e2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Re1 supports e4 and makes e5 more credible. Black has a broad d5-c5 center and may expand on the queenside while White builds a kingside initiative. Check whether e5 is safe, then consider Nf1 and h4 only if the center is stable. White's queen bishop needs a route, often through f4 or g5 after development.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Slav structures and active bishops

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KIA-07 - Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing it with ...e6. White cannot assume that Black has the restricted bishop of a French-type position.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Prepare e4 with adequate support, or choose c4 to challenge d5 directly. Consider Nh4 only if it wins a useful bishop exchange without neglecting the center.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

The bishop on f5 influences e4 and may move to g6 if chased. A knight trip can cost more time than the bishop is worth.

RECOGNITION TEST

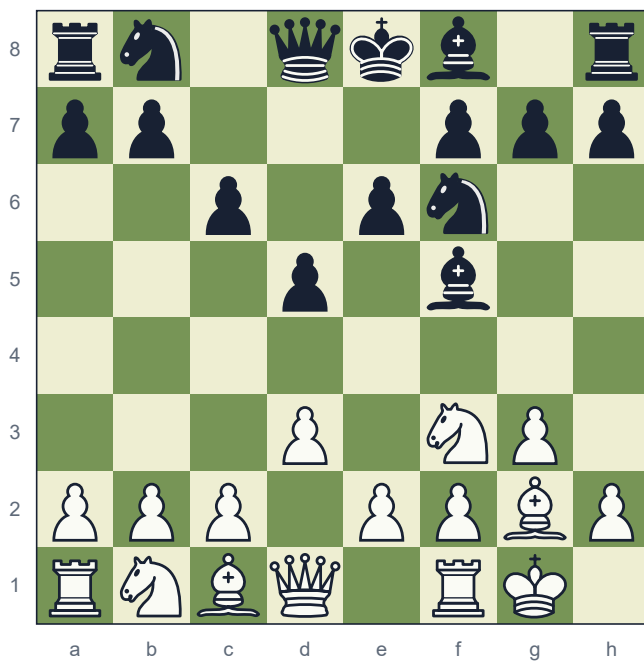
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KIA-07 / Slav setup: bishop outside the chain

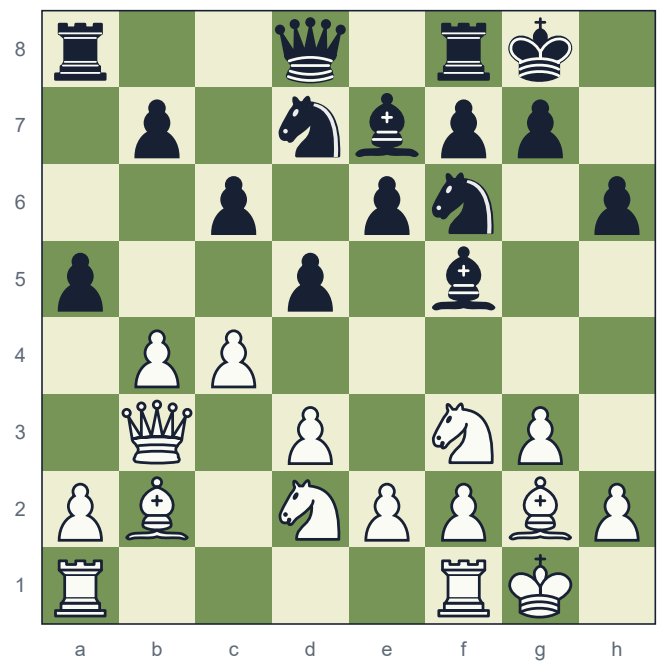
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 c6 4. O-O Bf5 5. d3 e6 6. Nbd2 h6 7. c4 Be7 8. b4 O-O 9. Qb3 Nbd7 10. Bb2 a5

Authored anchor ends after 6. Nbd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing it with ...e6. White cannot assume that Black has the restricted bishop of a French-type position.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Prepare e4 with adequate support, or choose c4 to challenge d5 directly. Consider Nh4 only if it wins a useful bishop exchange without neglecting the center.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The bishop on f5 influences e4 and may move to g6 if chased. A knight trip can cost more time than the bishop is worth.

REMEMBER Notice which bishop escaped the pawn chain.

KIA-08 / A direct central challenge with c4

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 c6 4. O-O Bf5 5. d3 e6 6. c4 dxc4 7. dxc4 Qxd1 8. Rxd1 Bc2 9. Rd2 Bf5 10. Nh4 Nbd7

Authored anchor ends after 7. dxc4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White changes the usual KIA pawn structure to challenge Black's center immediately. The d-pawn recapture opens the d-file and retains a central foothold.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the queen knight and contest the open file. Decide whether a later e4 gains space or simply creates a target.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can exchange queens or use ...Nbd7 and ...Be7 to complete development. The position is now closer to a Reti structure than an e5 attack.

REMEMBER c4 is a useful adaptation, not a failure of the system.

KIA-09 / Questioning Bf5 with Nh4

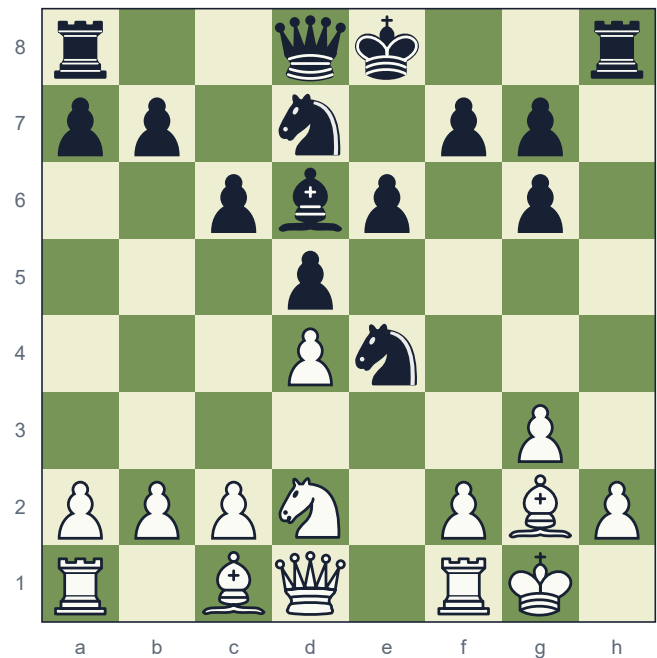
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 c6 4. O-O Bf5 5. d3 e6 6. Nh4 Bg6 7. Nxg6 hxg6 8. Nd2 Bd6 9. e4 Nbd7 10. d4 Nxe4

Authored anchor ends after 7... hxg6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White gives a knight for the active bishop and changes Black's kingside pawn structure. The open h-file can help Black as well as create targets.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the remaining pieces and use the bishop pair in a position that may open. Do not assume doubled pawns alone justify a direct attack.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's h8 rook now has an open file. Castling short was already a commitment, so watch pressure toward your own king.

REMEMBER A damaged pawn structure may open useful lines for its owner.

KIA-10 / The ...Bg4 pin

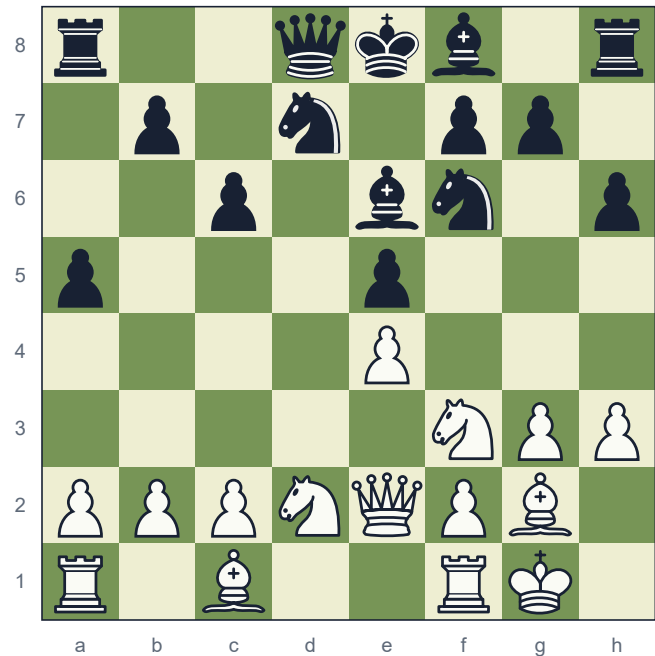
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 c6 4. O-O Bg4 5. d3 Nbd7 6. Nbd2 e5 7. e4 dxe4 8. dxe4 h6 9. h3 Be6 10. Qe2 a5

Authored anchor ends after 6... e5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black pins or pressures Nf3 and establishes a broad center. White needs a central plan before beginning a maneuvering attack.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Consider e4 if it holds, or c4 to challenge d5. h3 can ask the bishop a question but should serve development rather than become an isolated tempo.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

If Nf3 is exchanged, e4 may lose a defender. Count defenders after ...Bxf3 rather than before it.

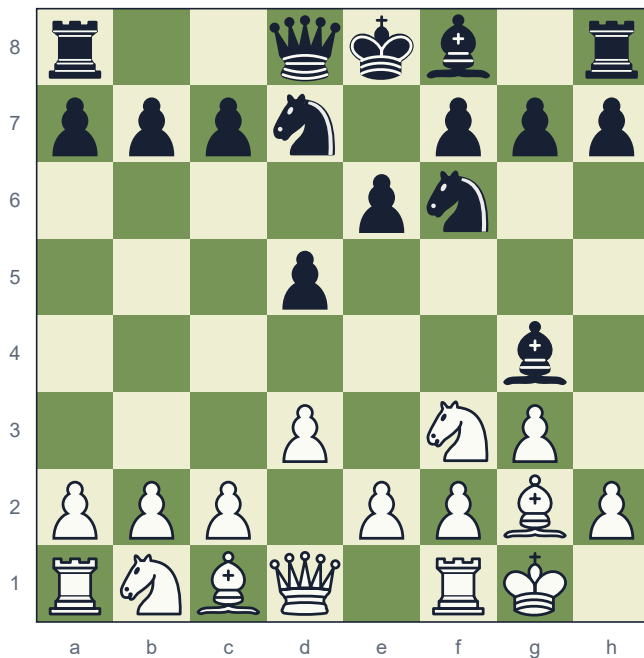
REMEMBER A pinned defender may not be a real defender.

KIA-11 / An early ...Bg4 without ...c6

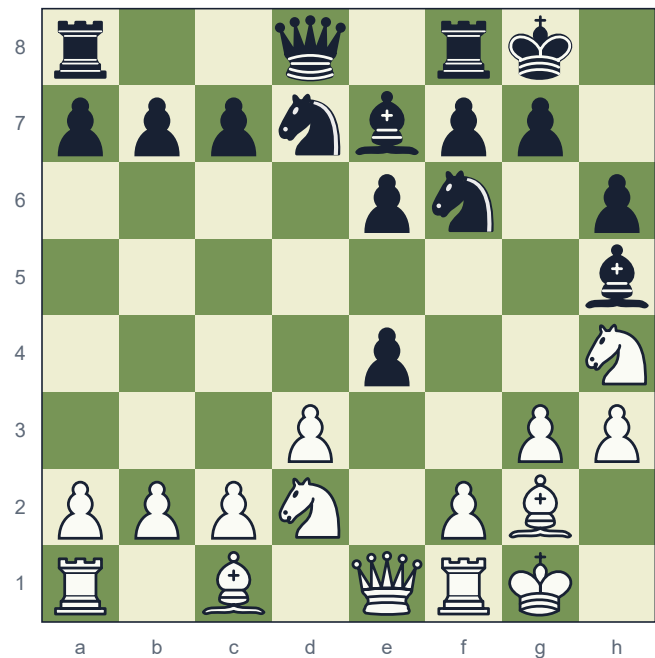
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Bg4 3. Bg2 Nd7 4. O-O e6 5. d3 Ngf6 6. Nbd2 Bh5 7. h3 h6 8. Qe1 Be7 9. e4 O-O 10. Nh4 dxe4

Authored anchor ends after 6. Nbd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops actively while retaining the c-pawn's choice between c5 and c6. White keeps the usual pieces but must watch central pressure.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use e4 with sufficient support and prepare Re1 if needed. The queen can sometimes unpin Nf3 by moving from d1, but move it only for a clear reason.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Copying the Slav plan can be inaccurate because Black can play ...c5 in one move. White's d3 pawn can become a target after central exchanges.

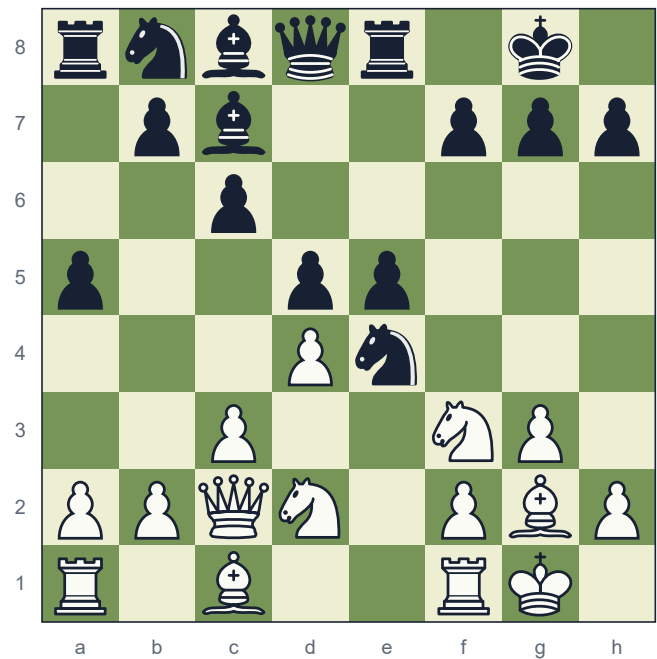
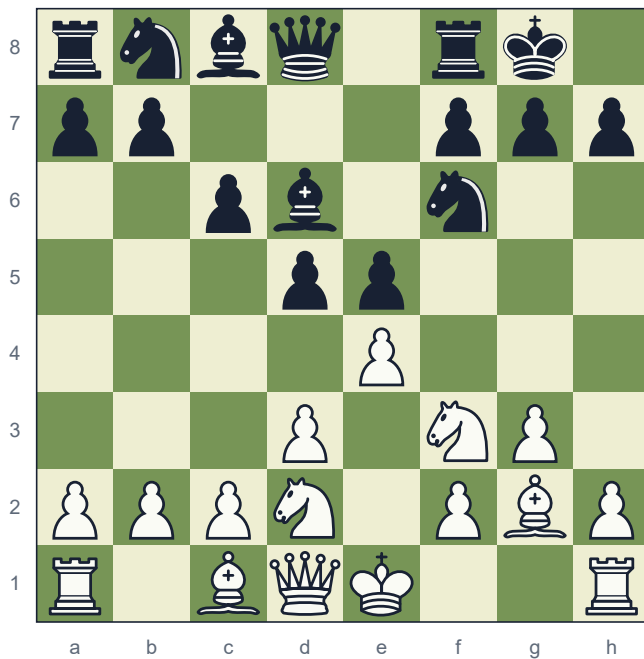
REMEMBER The location of the c-pawn changes the available break.

KIA-12 / Caro-Kann route with 1.e4

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 e5 4. Ngf3 Bd6 5. g3 Nf6 6. Bg2 O-O 7. O-O Bc7 8. c3 Re8 9. Qc2 a5 10. d4 Nxe4

Authored anchor ends after 7. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White can choose a KIA-style arrangement, but Black obtains an e5-d5 center and an active bishop. This is not the usual French target position.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Challenge the center with c3 and possibly d4, or prepare exd5 when the resulting files favor your pieces. Maintain a safe e4 pawn.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may gain space with ...d4. A rehearsed e5 push is impossible while Black occupies e5.

REMEMBER Name the actual central pawns before naming your attack.

Work through KIA-07

7. C4

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

8. B4

Places the pawn on b4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

9. QB3

Places the queen on b3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

10. BB2

Places the bishop on b2, attacking knight on f6. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing it with ...e6. White cannot assume that Black has the restricted bishop of a French-type position. Prepare e4 with adequate support, or choose c4 to challenge d5 directly. Consider Nh4 only if it wins a useful bishop exchange without neglecting the center.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Fianchettoes and other central structures

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KIA-13 - Both sides have fianchettoed and established restrained centers. White's extra move is useful, but the standard French-style kingside attack has no obvious hook.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Improve pieces and decide between c3-d4, c4 or a restrained queenside expansion. Compare the bishops' diagonals before exchanging central pawns.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

An unnecessary e5 can be captured or leave d5 weak. Black can challenge the center with ...c5 just as White can with c4.

RECOGNITION TEST

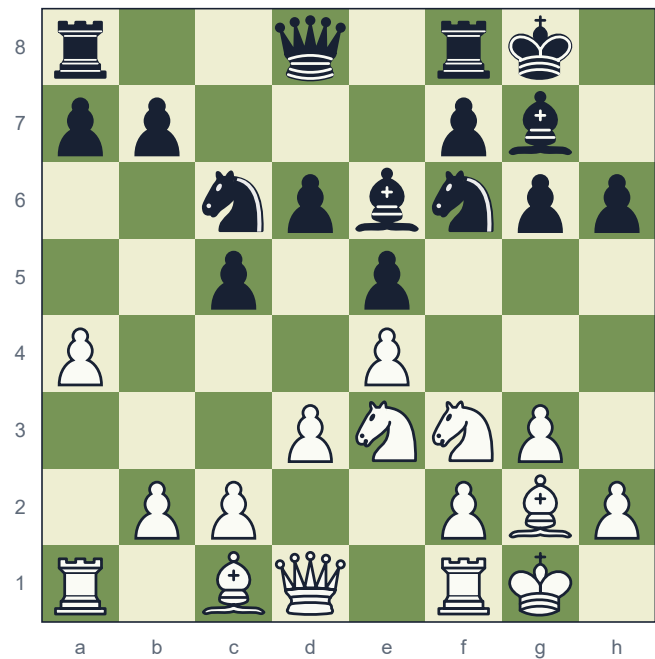
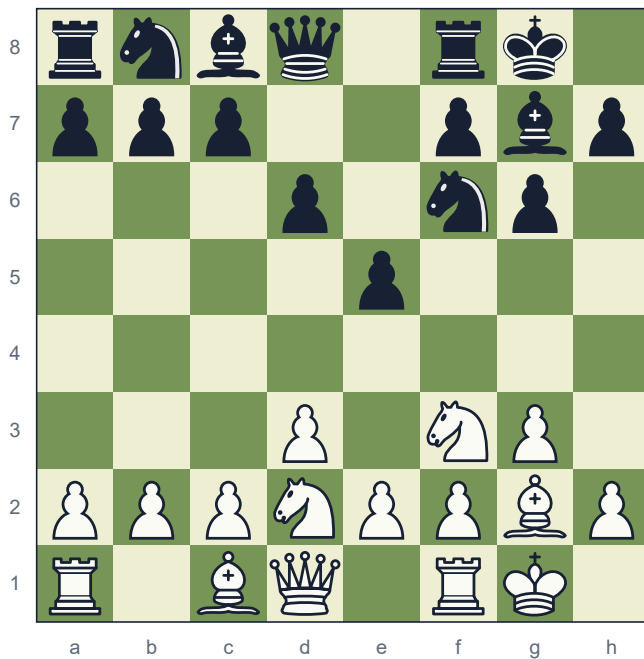
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KIA-13 / Symmetrical fianchetto

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 Nf6 2. g3 g6 3. Bg2 Bg7 4. O-O O-O 5. d3 d6 6. Nbd2 e5 7. e4 c5 8. a4 Nc6 9. Nc4 h6 10. Ne3 Be6

Authored anchor ends after 7. e4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Both sides have fianchettoed and established restrained centers. White's extra move is useful, but the standard French-style kingside attack has no obvious hook.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Improve pieces and decide between c3-d4, c4 or a restrained queenside expansion. Compare the bishops' diagonals before exchanging central pawns.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

An unnecessary e5 can be captured or leave d5 weak. Black can challenge the center with ...c5 just as White can with c4.

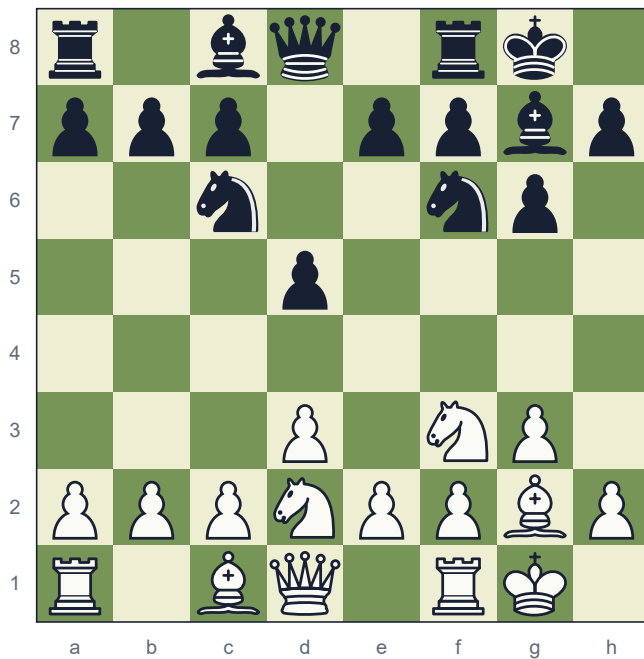
REMEMBER Symmetry calls for useful improvements, not an automatic pawn storm.

KIA-14 / Black chooses ...d5 in the fianchetto

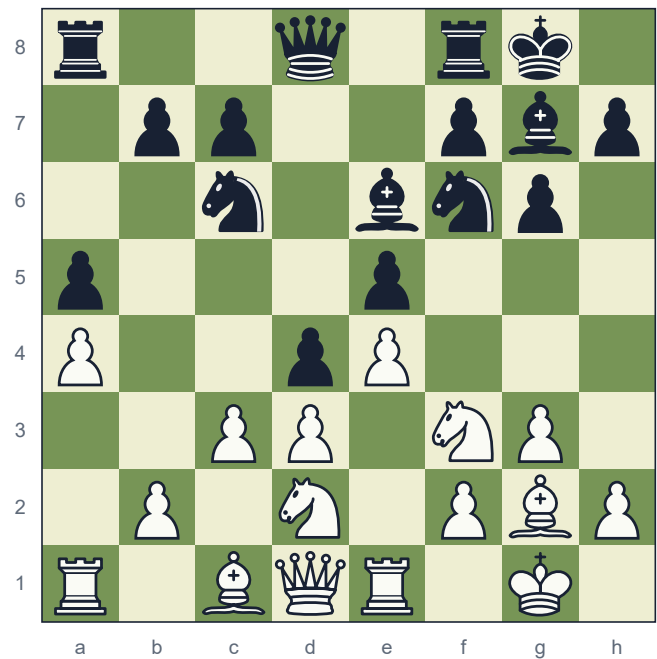
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 Nf6 2. g3 g6 3. Bg2 Bg7 4. O-O O-O 5. d3 d5 6. Nbd2 Nc6 7. e4 e5 8. a4 a5 9. c3 Be6 10. Re1 d4

Authored anchor ends after 7... e5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black claims a broad center. White may need a central exchange or a lever rather than another slow redeployment.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Consider exd5 and Re1, checking the recapture and pressure against e5. Look for c4 or c3-d4 only after comparing the resulting weak squares.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can advance ...d4 and squeeze the knights. Passivity is a practical risk even without a direct tactical threat.

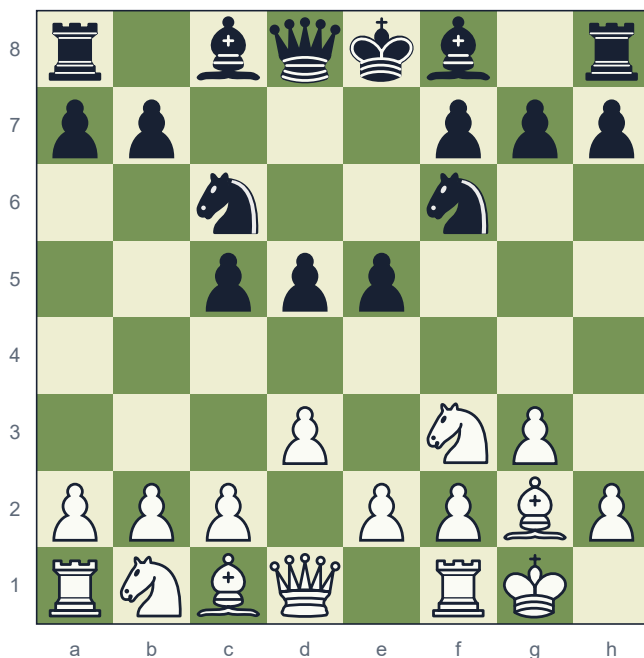
REMEMBER When the opponent occupies the center, plan the challenge.

KIA-15 / Reversed King's Indian structure

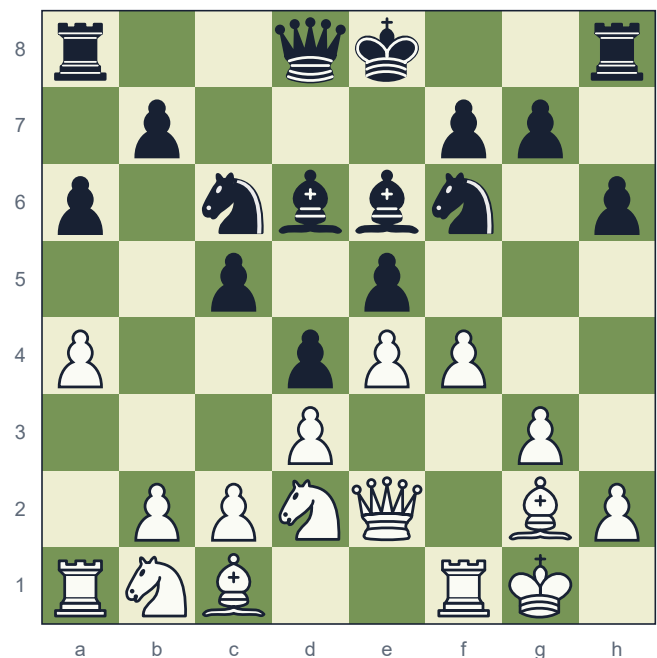
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 c5 3. Bg2 Nc6 4. O-O e5 5. d3 Nf6 6. e4 d4 7. a4 Bd6 8. Nfd2 a6 9. f4 h6 10. Qe2 Be6

Authored anchor ends after 6... d4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black closes the center with a space advantage. White has a reversed King's Indian type of position, but the move order and extra tempo require independent calculation.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Prepare a kingside lever with appropriate knight moves or use c3 to question d4. Choose a side based on the fixed pawn chain and king locations.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can expand with ...b5 and ...c4. A slow maneuver must be measured against the opponent's actual pawn-break timing.

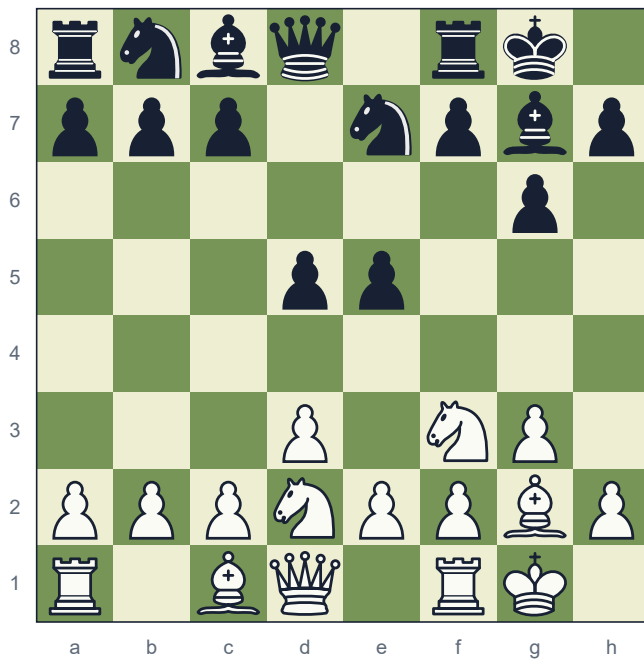
REMEMBER Reversed colors do not reverse every plan mechanically.

KIA-16 / The Pachman setup

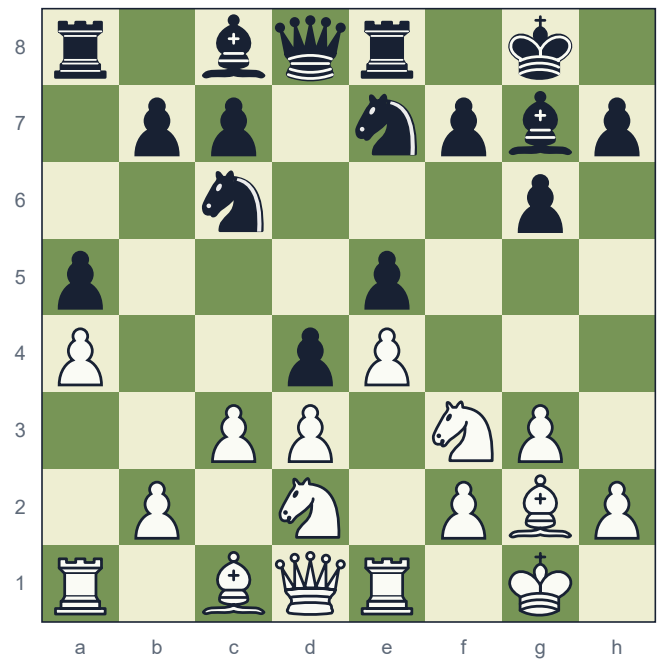
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 g6 3. Bg2 Bg7 4. O-O e5 5. d3 Ne7 6. Nbd2 O-O 7. e4 a5 8. a4 Re8 9. c3 Nbc6 10. Re1 d4

Authored anchor ends after 7. e4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops the king knight to e7 and holds d5-e5. The absence of a knight on f6 changes both e5 ideas and possible kingside exchanges.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use a central lever and complete development. Consider exd5 when the resulting open file can be used by a rook rather than merely exchanging for its own sake.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may play ...Nbc6 or ...c5, gaining more space. Do not waste a tempo preparing to displace a knight that is not on f6.

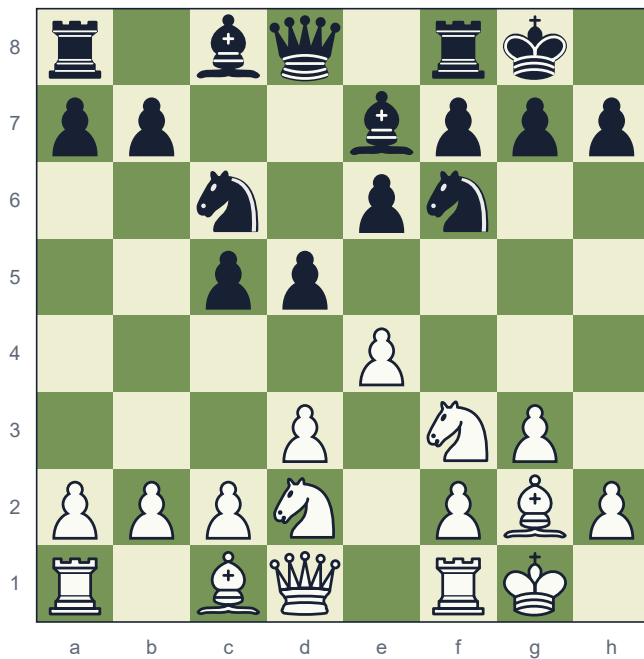
REMEMBER Count the real pieces around the intended pawn advance.

KIA-17 / Sicilian with ...e6

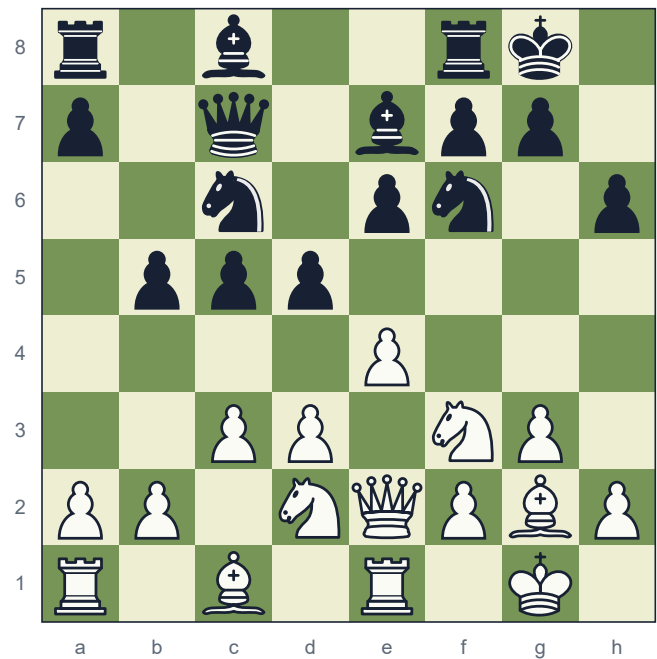
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d3 d5 4. Nbd2 Nc6 5. g3 Nf6 6. Bg2 Be7 7. O-O O-O 8. Re1 Qc7 9. c3 h6 10. Qe2 b5

Authored anchor ends after 8. Re1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

This 1.e4 route can reach the French-type center when Black chooses ...d5 and ...e6. White keeps familiar plans without opening the Sicilian with an immediate d4.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Support e4 and assess e5. If Black exchanges on e4, switch to open-file play instead of retaining the closed-center attacking script.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may delay ...d5, fianchetto or expand on the queenside. The same first three moves do not guarantee the same middlegame.

REMEMBER The Sicilian entry is useful when the center matches.

KIA-18 / Sicilian with ...d6

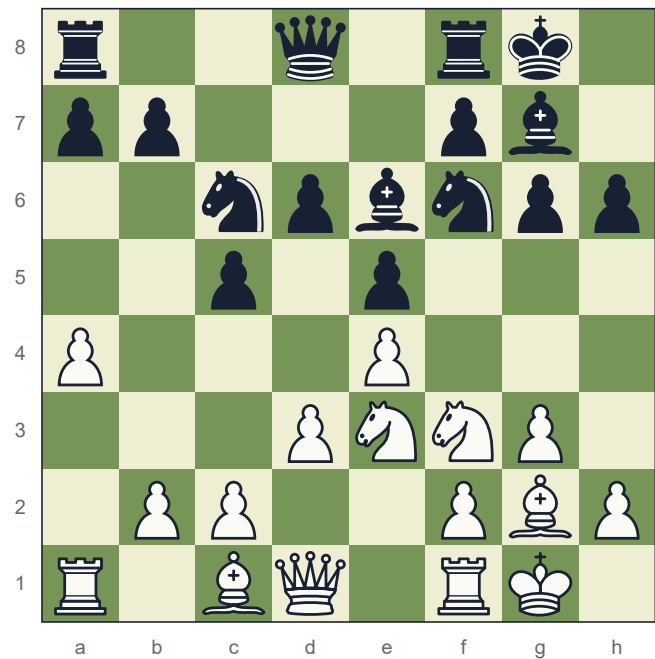
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d3 Nf6 4. g3 Nc6 5. Bg2 g6 6. O-O Bg7 7. Nbd2 O-O 8. a4 e5 9. Nc4 h6 10. Ne3 Be6

Authored anchor ends after 7... O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black fianchettoes and does not offer the French-type e6-d5 target. White's setup is playable but the main task is a central or queenside decision.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Prepare c3 and d4 if favorable, or c4 for a different space structure. Develop the queen bishop before starting a slow knight tour.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can play ...Rb8 and ...b5, or ...d5 when ready. Waiting only for an e5 attack can concede the initiative.

REMEMBER KIA piece placement does not guarantee a KIA attack.

Work through KIA-13

7. E4

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

8. A4

Places the pawn on a4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

9. NC4

Places the knight on c4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

10. NE3

Places the knight on e3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Both sides have fianchettoed and established restrained centers. White's extra move is useful, but the standard French-style kingside attack has no obvious hook. Improve pieces and decide between c3-d4, c4 or a restrained queenside expansion. Compare the bishops' diagonals before exchanging central pawns.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

First-move choices and useful adaptations

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KIA-19 - Starting with Nf3 allows Black a Sicilian-like or English-like structure. White can establish e4 after seeing Black's fianchetto.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Finish development with Nbd2 or Nc3 according to the desired pawn break. Decide whether c3-d4 or c4 gives the pieces the best squares.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

Nc3 blocks the c-pawn temporarily, while Nbd2 can crowd the queen bishop. Each knight square carries a structural commitment.

RECOGNITION TEST

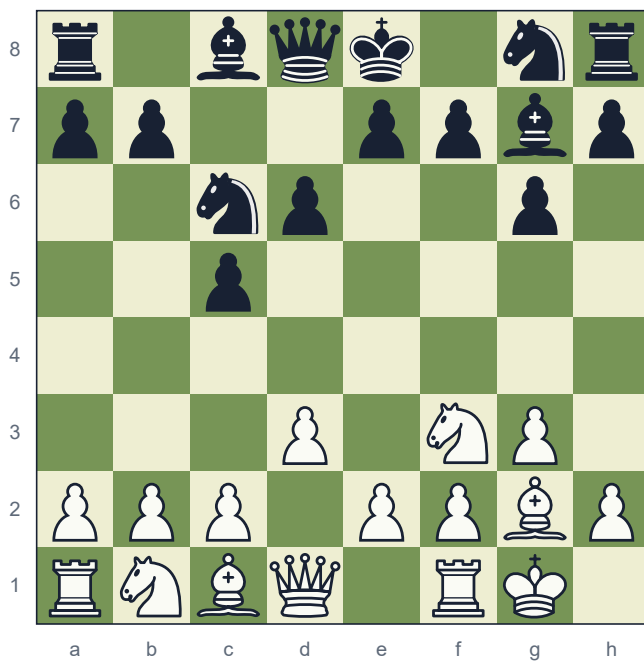
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KIA-19 / Black plays ...c5 on move one

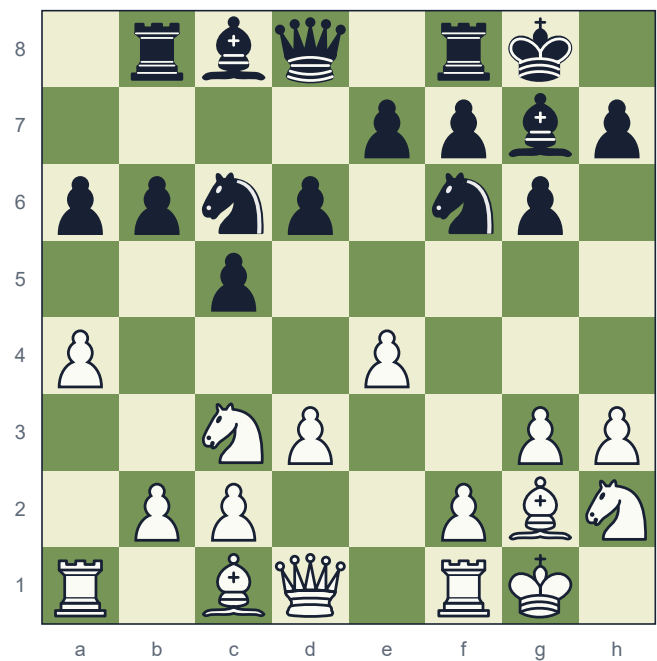
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 c5 2. g3 Nc6 3. Bg2 g6 4. O-O Bg7 5. d3 d6 6. e4 Nf6 7. a4 O-O 8. Nc3 Rb8 9. h3 b6 10. Nh2 a6

Authored anchor ends after 6. e4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Starting with Nf3 allows Black a Sicilian-like or English-like structure. White can establish e4 after seeing Black's fianchetto.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Finish development with Nbd2 or Nc3 according to the desired pawn break. Decide whether c3-d4 or c4 gives the pieces the best squares.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Nc3 blocks the c-pawn temporarily, while Nbd2 can crowd the queen bishop. Each knight square carries a structural commitment.

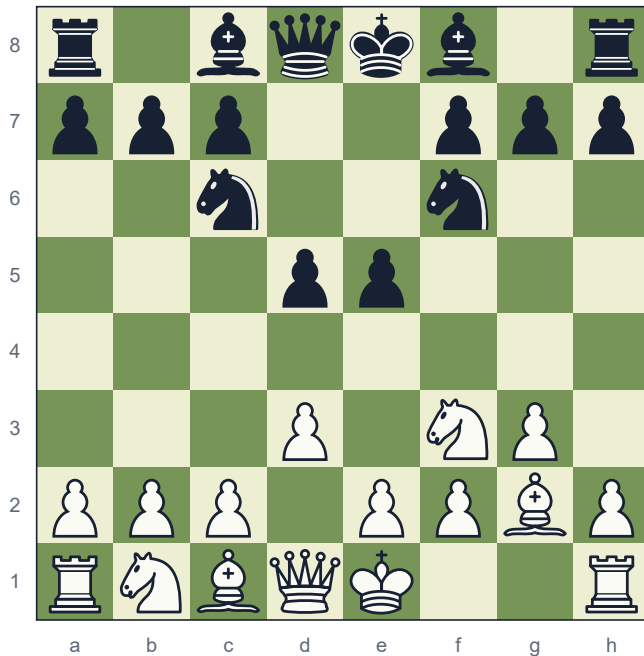
REMEMBER Pick the knight square to support a plan.

KIA-20 / Black occupies e5 immediately

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 Nc6 2. g3 e5 3. d3 d5 4. Bg2 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. c4 O-O 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Nc3 Be6 9. d4 exd4 10. Nxd4 Nxd4

Authored anchor ends after 5... Be7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Black has gained a large center. White completes development while preparing a challenge; there is no obligation to finish every standard KIA move first.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use c4 or e4 only after calculating exchanges. Develop the queen knight to a square that supports the chosen lever.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can push ...e4 to attack Nf3 if the pawn is supported. Watch that immediate threat before choosing a quiet move.

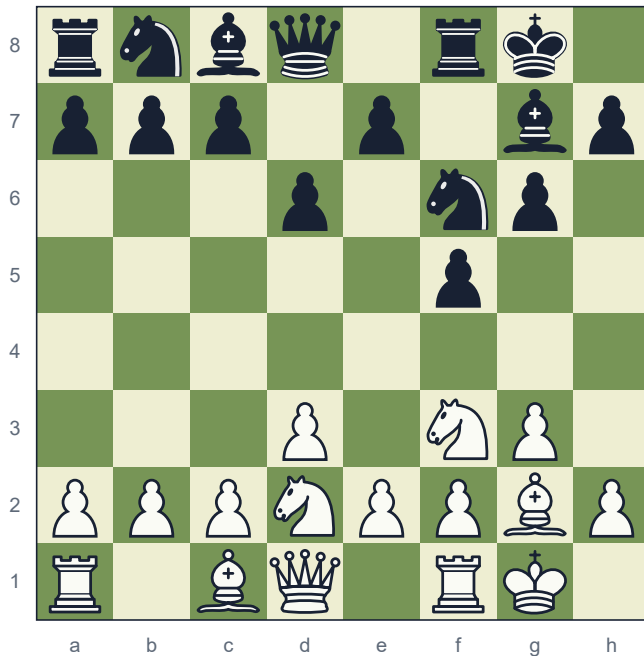
REMEMBER A pawn attack on a piece overrides a setup plan.

KIA-21 / Dutch-style ...f5

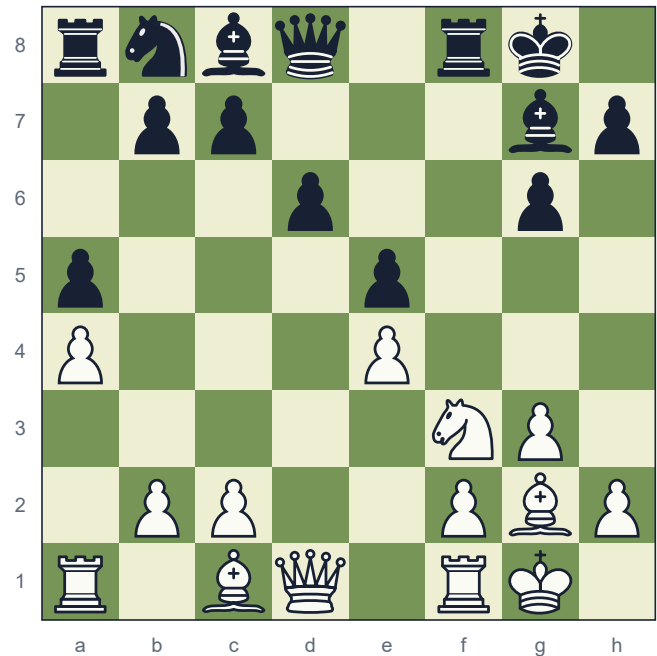
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 f5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 g6 4. O-O Bg7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 d6 7. e4 fxe4 8. Nxe4 Nxe4 9. dxe4 e5 10. a4 a5

Authored anchor ends after 7. e4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White challenges Black's kingside space through e4. Black's f-pawn move creates a different set of dark-square weaknesses and attacking chances.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Calculate ...fxe4 and dxe4, develop the queen bishop and watch the e-file. A later c3 can prepare a central expansion.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may use ...e5 and ...Nc6 to support a broad center. The g7 bishop and f-file can become active after exchanges.

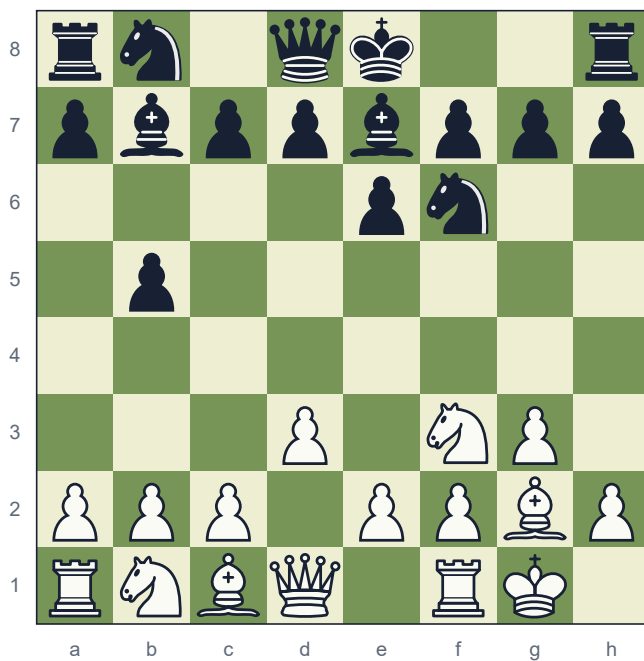
REMEMBER Meet wing space with a supported central challenge.

KIA-22 / The ...b5 flank expansion

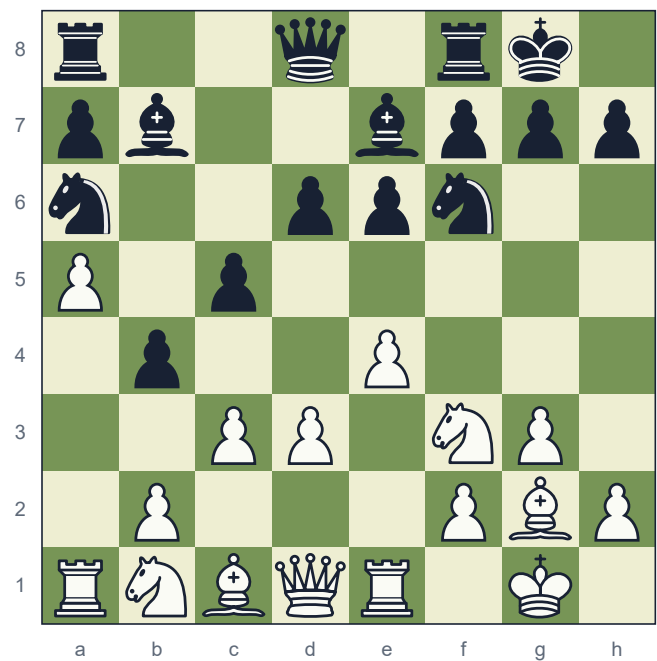
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 Nf6 2. g3 b5 3. Bg2 Bb7 4. O-O e6 5. d3 Be7 6. e4 d6 7. a4 b4 8. a5 c5 9. c3 O-O 10. Re1 Na6

Authored anchor ends after 6. e4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black gains queenside space and develops the bishop to b7. White uses the time to establish e4 but must notice the long diagonal toward the king side.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Nbd2 and support the center. a4 may question b5 if it creates a useful weakness without costing a central tempo.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can pressure e4 after ...d5 or ...c5. A flank pawn advance may be part of central control, not merely a waste of time.

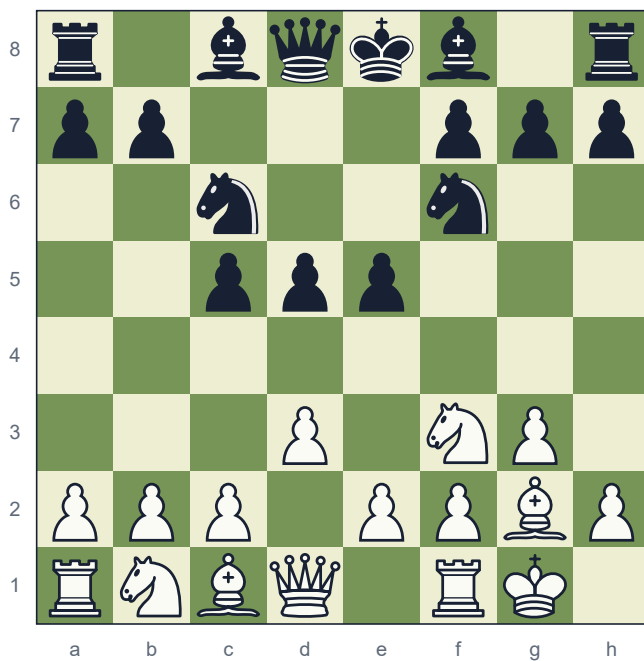
REMEMBER Ask what the flank bishop attacks.

KIA-23 / Early ...d4 before the setup

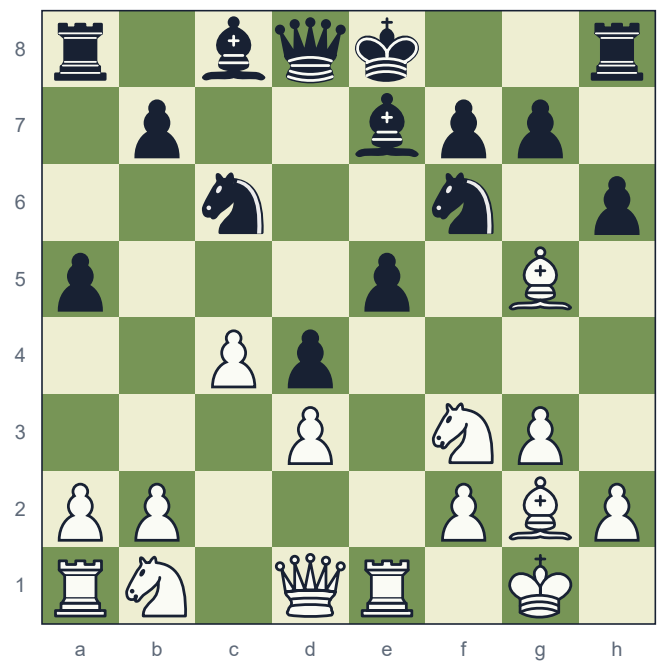
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 c5 3. Bg2 Nc6 4. O-O e5 5. d3 Nf6 6. c4 d4 7. e3 Be7 8. exd4 cxd4 9. Bg5 a5 10. Re1 h6

Authored anchor ends after 6... d4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White chooses c4 before e4 to challenge the broad center. Once Black closes with ...d4, the result belongs to a different structure from the main KIA attack.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Decide between e3 to undermine d4 and queenside development. Keep the g2 bishop's diagonal in mind when opening the center.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's d4 pawn restricts Nc3. Putting a piece on a square controlled by that pawn is a concrete error, regardless of a familiar development pattern.

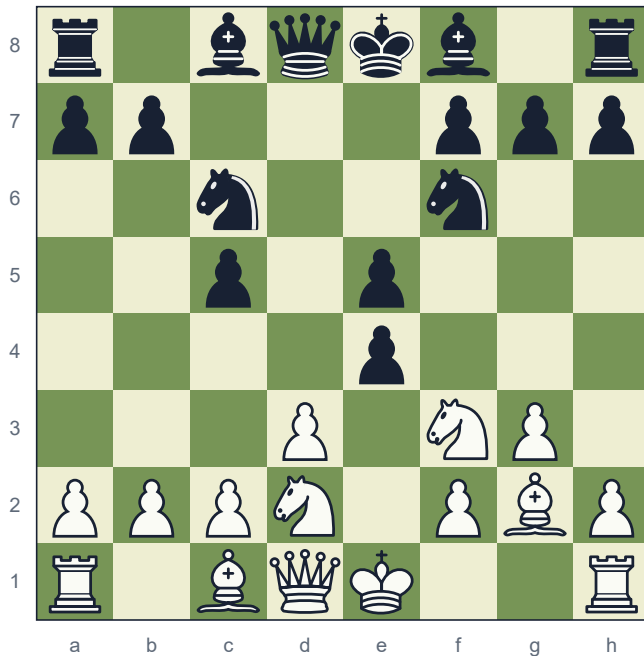
REMEMBER Adapt the pawn structure before copying the piece setup.

KIA-24 / Early central exchange before castling

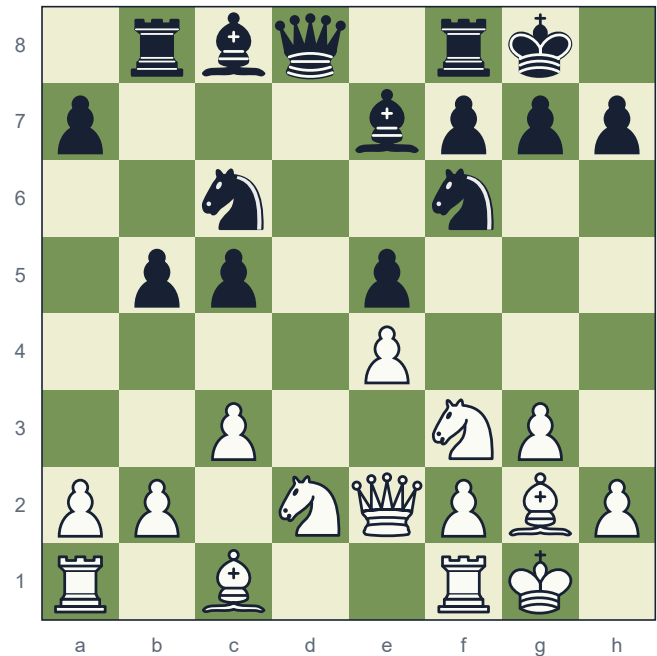
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 c5 4. d3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 e5 6. e4 dxe4 7. dxe4 Be7 8. c3 b5 9. Qe2 Rb8 10. O-O O-O

Authored anchor ends after 7. dxe4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White delays castling while constructing the center. The exchange on e4 opens the d-file and makes queen exchanges a practical possibility.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare castling with a useful queen move, then develop the queen bishop. Open-file control may matter more than preserving queens for an attack.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can exchange queens if the file opens completely. Evaluate the king's destination in the resulting endgame rather than fearing a lost castling right automatically.

REMEMBER Queen exchange can change what king safety means.

Work through KIA-19

7. A4

Places the pawn on a4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

8. NC3

Develops toward d5 and e4. Compare its central influence with the fact that it blocks the c-pawn.

9. H3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

10. NH2

Places the knight on h2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Starting with Nf3 allows Black a Sicilian-like or English-like structure. White can establish e4 after seeing Black's fianchetto. Finish development with Nbd2 or Nc3 according to the desired pawn break. Decide whether c3-d4 or c4 gives the pieces the best squares.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.